

D

"DO YOU WISH to see the future of energy?" asks Hardeep Singh Puri, Union Minister of Petroleum and Natural Gas, during an interaction with *Business Today*. "Well, it's right there!" As the afternoon sun clears up the leftover January fog, a row of solar panels gleam on the roof of his sprawling bungalow in New Delhi's Lutyens zone. "India's energy transition in some respects is a sui generis case. The country has to ensure the transition to green and sustainable energy without affecting energy availability and affordability," he emphasises.

The panels on the roof of Puri's official residence serve as an apt metaphor for India's ambitious target of achieving net zero emissions by 2070. The country is looking at getting there by meeting 50 per

cent of its electricity requirements through renewable energy, which is the highest among G20 economies.

India has made significant progress in this direction. By November 2021, it had successfully installed 156.83 gigawatt (GW) of green energy, or over 40 per cent of the target capacity (390.8 GW) of 2030—a full nine years ahead of schedule. A confident Raj Kumar Singh, Union Minister of Power, New & Renewable Energy, claims that India is now all set to breach the revised projection for 2030. "I will tell you right now that 65 per cent is an understatement as our established capacity today is 170-odd GW of non-fossil. We have about another 80 GW under construction. That makes it 250 GW!"

"Combating the ongoing climate crisis needs strong global cooperation to accelerate the transition to cleaner energy resources," says Anil Chaudhry, Zone President and CEO & MD of Schneider Electric India. Referring to India's current presidency of the G20, he believes that it will provide significant opportunities for the country to accelerate and demonstrate the actions being taken to meet its clean energy commitments. "India is exhibiting one of the fastest transitions to renewable energy," says Chaudhry. Adds Praveer Sinha, CEO & MD of Tata Power: "From launching the International Solar Alliance in 2015 to setting a target of reaching net zero emissions by 2070, India is on the

path of transformation. The 2030 goals that may seem very daunting and difficult are achievable, with support and commitment from all stakeholders."

Over the next few years, Sinha expects to see movement on newer technologies, including battery storage, green hydrogen and small modular nuclear plants leading the growth of clean energy in the country.

ENERGY SECURITY

Amid reports of India already having overtaken China in population, both Puri and Singh would be mindful of the actions being taken by their ministries today, laying a firm foundation in ensuring the country's energy security. This is required to meet the prerequisite of rapid urbanisation, expansion of transportation infrastructure, increase in industrial production and a growth in electricity consumption in the decades to come. India, the world's fifth-largest economy, imports nearly 85 per cent of its oil and 45 per cent of its gas requirements every year. And ever since the start of the Russian military action in Ukraine a year ago, Puri is often found aggressively defending India's purchase of Russian oil at several international forums. "If you have friends who are willing to sell us oil at a lesser rate, we will buy from them," he tells *BT* in a lighter vein. In FY22, the country witnessed a 100 per cent increase in its oil import bill to \$119 billion on the back of a recov-

GETTING ON THE GRID



▶ **India is now the world's third-largest energy importer, with coal and oil currently powering economic growth in the country**



▶ **The country's oil import bill surged 76 per cent to \$90.3 billion in the first half of FY23 even as it imported 15 per cent more oil during this period**